

Business Analyst Interview Q&A

Technical round

1. How would you describe the role of a business analyst?

For me, a BA is basically the bridge between the business side and the tech side. The business knows what problem they have, and the developers know how to build things, but they don't always speak the same language. So my job is to understand the problem properly, talk to the right people, work out what's actually needed, and turn that into clear requirements the team can build and test against. And it doesn't stop there. A good BA stays involved through delivery, checks that what's built actually solves the problem, and uses data to show whether it's working. Coming from a software background, I like that I can understand both sides of that conversation.

2. How do you gather requirements?

It depends on the project, but I usually start with one-on-one interviews with the key stakeholders, because that's where you hear the real pain points. If there are a few groups involved, I'll run a workshop so everyone's in the same room and we can sort out conflicts early. I also look at existing documents and systems, and sometimes just watch how people do the work, because what people say and what they actually do can be pretty different. In my Green Miles project, we had weekly meetings with the client, and after each one, I'd write up what we heard as user stories and send it back to confirm. That confirmation step catches misunderstandings before they turn into rework.

3. What's the difference between functional and non-functional requirements?

Functional requirements are about what the system does, like "the user can add an item to a checklist" or "the app calculates carbon savings for a trip." Non-functional requirements are about how well it does it, so things like performance, security, usability and reliability. A good example is Task Loop, the app I built at Motivolog. The functional side was the checklist features, but two big non-functional requirements were that it had to work fully offline and it couldn't collect any user data. Those non-functional ones often get missed early, and they're usually the ones that cause the biggest problems later, so I try to ask about them upfront.

4. How do you write a good user story and acceptance criteria?

I use the standard format: "As a [type of user], I want [something], so that [benefit]." The "so that" part is the most important, because it explains why we're building it. Then I add acceptance criteria, usually in Given, When, Then format, so it's really clear when the story is done. For example, "Given I've finished a trip, when I open the summary, then I can see how much CO2 I saved compared to a petrol car." I also check the story against INVEST, so it's independent, small enough to fit in a sprint, and testable. If a tester can't write a test from it, it's not ready yet.

5. How do you prioritise requirements?

I mostly use MoSCoW, so Must have, Should have, Could have and Won't have for now. It's simple and stakeholders pick it up quickly. I'll also look at business value against effort, because sometimes a small feature gives a lot of value and it makes sense to do it early. In Green Miles the client had lots of ideas and we only had six sprints, so we couldn't do everything. We agreed the must-haves were GPS trip tracking and the carbon calculation, and the nice-to-haves went further down the backlog. The key thing is that the business makes the final call on priority. My job is to give them the right information to make that call.

6. What kind of documentation have you worked with?

Across my internships and projects I've written requirement documents, user stories and backlogs in Jira, process maps, technical documentation and progress reports for my team leads. In Green Miles we also did a full handover document at the end, so whoever picks up the app next understands how it works and why decisions were made. I'm also familiar with the standard BA documents like the BRD, which covers what the business needs and why, and the FRD, which goes into how the system should behave. I try to keep documents short and easy to scan, because if a document is too long, people just won't read it.

7. How do you approach process mapping, and what tools do you use?

I usually start with the As-Is process, so how things work right now, by talking to the people who actually do the work. That's where you find the bottlenecks, the manual steps, and the handoffs where things get lost. Then I map the To-Be process, which is how it should work after the change. I like swimlane diagrams because you can clearly see who's responsible for each step, and I follow BPMN notation where it makes sense. For tools, I've used Visio, Lucidchart and draw.io for the proper diagrams, and Miro when I'm mapping live with people in a workshop because it's more collaborative. I also did a LinkedIn Learning course on business process mapping, which helped me get the notation right.

8. What is gap analysis?

Gap analysis is basically comparing where the business is now with where it wants to be, and working out what's missing in between. So you've got the current state, the future state, and the gap, which could be a missing system feature, a manual process, a skills gap or missing data. Then you work out what needs to happen to close each gap. It connects nicely with process mapping, because once your As-Is and To-Be maps are side by side, the gaps are usually pretty obvious. I did something similar in my competitor analysis at Motivolog, where we looked at what other tools were offering and where is.team stood against them.

9. How do you identify and manage stakeholders?

First I list everyone who's affected by the project or has a say in it, not just the obvious people. Then I put them on a power-interest grid, so the high-power, high-interest people I work with closely, and others I keep informed. A RACI chart is also useful to make it clear who's responsible, who approves, who needs to be consulted, and who just needs updates. In Green Miles, stakeholder analysis helped us figure out who our target users actually were, like daily commuters and people who care about

sustainability, and that shaped the features a lot. After that, it's mostly about regular, clear communication so nobody gets surprised.

10. How do you approach competitor analysis?

I start by being clear on the question we're trying to answer, because competitor analysis can get really broad really fast. At Motivolog, the question was about pricing and licensing, so I compared open-core licensing and pricing across 11 competing tools in a comparison matrix, covering what's free, what's paid, the price tiers and the licence type. From that I could spot patterns and recommend a strategy for is.team. In Green Miles it was more about features and positioning, so we looked at Strava, MyFitnessPal and carbon footprint apps to see what they did well and where there was a gap we could fill. I sometimes finish with a SWOT to summarise it for stakeholders.

11. How do you use SQL as a business analyst?

I mainly use SQL to pull and check data myself instead of waiting on someone else. So things like filtering records, joining tables, and using GROUP BY with COUNT or SUM to get summaries. For example, if a stakeholder asked which suburbs had the most property listings last quarter, I'd join the listings and location tables, filter by date, group by suburb, and sort from highest to lowest. I also use SQL to check data before it goes into a report, like looking for duplicates or missing values. I've used PostgreSQL in my projects, and I did a LinkedIn Learning course on solving business problems with SQL, which was really practical.

12. What's the difference between an INNER JOIN and a LEFT JOIN, and between WHERE and HAVING?

An INNER JOIN only gives you rows where there's a match in both tables. A LEFT JOIN gives you everything from the left table, and if there's no match on the right, those columns just come back as null. So if I want all customers, including the ones who haven't placed an order yet, I'd use a LEFT JOIN, because an INNER JOIN would drop them. For WHERE and HAVING, WHERE filters individual rows before any grouping happens, and HAVING filters the groups after the GROUP BY. So WHERE status = 'active' filters rows, but HAVING COUNT(orders) > 5 filters the grouped results. It's a small difference, but it really matters for getting the right numbers.

13. Walk me through how you'd build a Power BI dashboard.

I always start with the questions, not the charts. So I'll ask the stakeholder what decisions they want to make with the dashboard and which KPIs matter to them. Then I connect to the data and clean it up in Power Query, like fixing data types, removing duplicates and handling blanks. Next I set up the data model with the right relationships, usually a simple star schema, and write DAX measures for things like totals, averages or month-on-month change. Then I build the visuals, keeping it simple, with the key numbers at the top and slicers so people can filter. Finally I show it to the users, get feedback and adjust it, because a dashboard nobody uses doesn't help anyone.

14. When would you use Excel, Power BI or Tableau?

Excel is great for quick analysis, one-off tasks and smaller data sets, things like pivot tables, XLOOKUP and quick what-if calculations. Everyone in the business already knows it, so it's easy to share. Power BI

is better when you need a dashboard that refreshes regularly, pulls from several sources and gets shared across a team, and it fits really well if the organisation already uses Microsoft 365 with Teams and SharePoint. Tableau does a similar job to Power BI and it's really strong for visual exploration. In practice I'd go with whatever the organisation already uses, because the best tool is the one people will actually open.

15. How do you use Jira and Confluence?

In Jira, I set up the backlog with epics for the big features and break them down into user stories with acceptance criteria. In sprint planning we pull stories into the sprint, and the board shows what's in progress, in review or done. I also use it to log bugs from testing and link them back to the story. Confluence is where the bigger-picture documentation lives, like requirements pages, meeting notes, process maps and decision logs, and I link those pages to the Jira tickets so everything's connected. In Green Miles we ran all six sprints in Jira, and I've got the Atlassian Agile Project Management Professional Certificate, so I'm pretty comfortable in both.

16. What's the difference between Agile and Waterfall, and which do you prefer?

Waterfall is sequential, so you do all the requirements first, then design, build and test, and deliver at the end. It works well when requirements are clear and unlikely to change, like fixed-scope or heavily regulated projects. Agile delivers in short sprints, so you get working pieces early, get feedback and adjust as you go. Most of my experience has been in Agile teams, in my internships and in Green Miles, and I like it because you catch problems early instead of at the end. But I don't think one is always better. A lot of organisations, especially in government, use a hybrid, with some planning upfront and then Agile delivery, and I'm comfortable working either way.

17. What does a BA do in a Scrum team?

In Scrum, the BA works really closely with the Product Owner. I help keep the backlog in good shape, so writing and refining user stories, adding acceptance criteria, and making sure stories are ready before sprint planning. During the sprint I'm the go-to person when developers have questions about a requirement, so they're not stuck waiting. In the sprint review I help demo what's been built and capture stakeholder feedback, which then goes back into the backlog. At Spider Communication and ViitorCloud I joined sprint planning and did progress reporting, and I saw how much smoother a sprint goes when the stories are clear before it starts.

18. How do you use prototypes and wireframes?

Prototypes are one of my favourite tools, because people react much better to something they can see than to a written requirement. In Green Miles I built a Figma prototype and walked the client through it, and they picked up things straight away that would have been missed in a document. It's much cheaper to change a Figma screen than to change code after it's built. I usually start low fidelity, even just boxes on a Miro board, to agree on the flow, and then add detail once the basic structure is right. I've also done LinkedIn Learning courses on UX prototyping and designing product interaction.

19. What is UAT, and how do you support testing?

UAT is User Acceptance Testing. It's the final check where real users test the system to confirm it does what the business needs before it goes live. As a BA, I'd help write the UAT scenarios based on the acceptance criteria, organise the users who'll be testing, and log and track any issues that come up. A requirements traceability matrix helps a lot here, because it links each requirement to its test cases, so you can show everything's been covered. In Green Miles we did QA testing every sprint, and in my internships I did a lot of testing and debugging, so I know how important it is to test real scenarios and not just the happy path.

20. How do you make sure your data and analysis are accurate?

I don't fully trust data until I've checked it. So I look for duplicates, missing values, odd outliers and totals that don't add up, and I cross-check against a known source where I can. I use Excel or SQL for quick checks, and Python with pandas when the data is bigger or messier. A good example is OneShot, the duplicate photo cleaner I built at Motivolog. Instead of assuming the results were right, I tested them against a ground-truth dataset, and that showed the previous approach was missing 30 to 43 percent of true duplicates. So now I always test against something real before I put a number in front of anyone.

Behavioral (HR) round

1. Tell me about yourself.

Sure. I'm Rahil, I'm doing my Master of IT in Software Engineering at Charles Darwin University here in Darwin, and before that I did a Bachelor of Computer Engineering in India. Over the last few years I've done a few internships, mostly in software and data, and right now I'm interning at Motivolog, where I've done competitor and pricing analysis and also built and released two mobile apps. What I've noticed across all of it is that the part I enjoy most is understanding the problem, talking to people and working out what actually needs to be built. That's why I'm moving into business analysis. I've got my Atlassian Agile certificate, I'm comfortable with SQL and Power BI, and I'm really keen to start my BA career here in the Territory.

2. Why do you want to be a BA when your background is in software engineering?

When I was working as a developer in my internships, I kept noticing that the biggest problems usually weren't technical. They came from requirements that weren't clear, or from the business and the developers understanding something differently. And I found I was really interested in that side of things, sitting in the meetings, asking questions and making sure everyone was on the same page. In Green Miles I got to do that properly, running requirements with the client every week and managing the backlog, and I really enjoyed it. I think my technical background is a strength here, because I know what developers need from a requirement and I can have realistic conversations about what's possible.

3. Why do you want to work here?

I've been looking into [company name], and what stood out to me was [one specific thing, like a recent project, a service they run, or their community work]. I'm based in Darwin and I want to build my career here in the Territory, not just use it as a stepping stone. I like that the NT is a smaller community, so the work you do has a visible impact on people. And from the job description, this role needs someone who

can work with stakeholders, document requirements and work with data, which lines up really well with what I've been doing. I'm looking for a place where I can learn from experienced BAs and contribute at the same time, and this feels like that kind of place.

4. What are your strengths?

I'd say my biggest strength is communication, especially explaining technical things in a simple way. Because of my software background, I can talk to developers in their language, but I can also sit with a client and explain things without the jargon. Another strength is that I'm quite curious. I like asking "why" a few times to get to the real problem, not just the first thing someone asks for. And I'm pretty detail-oriented, especially with data. I like to double-check numbers before I share them, because one wrong figure in a report can make people stop trusting the whole thing.

5. What's your biggest weakness?

One thing I've been working on is that I sometimes spend too long trying to make something perfect before I share it. With a document or a report, I'd keep polishing it on my own when it would have been better to get feedback earlier. I realised that, in Agile especially, getting something rough in front of people early is much more useful, because they often change direction anyway. So now I timebox my work and share a first draft early, even if it's not perfect, and then improve it based on feedback. It's gotten a lot better, but it's still something I keep an eye on.

6. Tell me about a time you explained something technical to a non-technical person.

In Green Miles, our client wasn't from a technical background, and we needed to explain how the app calculates carbon savings using GPS data and a petrol car baseline. Instead of going into the technical details, I used a simple example: if you ride your bike 10 kilometres to work, here's what that same trip would have produced in a petrol car, and the difference is your saving. I also showed it in the Figma prototype so they could see how it would look to users. They got it straight away and gave us useful feedback on how to present it. I learned that a simple example and a visual usually work much better than a long explanation.

7. Tell me about a time you dealt with a difficult stakeholder.

In Green Miles, the client had lots of great ideas, but they wanted pretty much everything treated as high priority, and we only had six sprints. It started to get a bit tense. Instead of just saying no, I sat down with them and went through the backlog together using MoSCoW, and showed what could realistically fit in each sprint. Once they could see the trade-offs themselves, they were much more open, and we agreed on the must-haves. I also made sure the lower-priority ideas stayed in the backlog, so they didn't feel ignored. That made a big difference to the relationship, and the rest of the project went a lot more smoothly.

8. Tell me about a time requirements changed in the middle of a project.

In Green Miles, the client came back partway through with a new feature idea after seeing a sprint review. My first step was to understand why they wanted it and what problem it solved, because sometimes there's a simpler way to get the same result. Then I looked at the impact, so how much effort it would take and what would have to move to make room for it. I laid that out for the client and let

them decide, and we added it to the backlog and moved a lower-priority story out of the sprint. I also updated the stories in Jira so everyone was working from the same version. I think change is normal in Agile. The key is to make the trade-off visible, not just quietly absorb it.

9. Tell me about a time you disagreed with a teammate.

In one of my uni group projects, a teammate wanted to start coding straight away, and I wanted to spend a bit more time confirming requirements with the client first. Instead of arguing about it, I suggested a middle ground. We'd spend a couple of days on a quick prototype and a requirements check, and then start building. When we showed the prototype to the client, they changed a few things, which saved us from rebuilding them later. My teammate agreed it was worth it, and we worked really well together after that. I learned it's better to focus on the shared goal than on who's right.

10. Tell me about a time you worked under a tight deadline.

At ViitorCloud I was working on part of a predictive analytics model, and my module had a fixed delivery date. Partway through, the data cleaning took much longer than planned because the data was messier than we expected. Instead of staying quiet and hoping to catch up, I raised it early in our stand-up, broke the remaining work into smaller tasks, and agreed with my senior to focus on the core model first and leave some improvements for later. We delivered the module on schedule. What I took from it is that flagging a risk early is always better than surprising people at the last minute.

11. Tell me about a mistake you made and what you learned.

During my web development internship at Amivir, I was working on the hotel booking site, and I built part of the search feature based on how I assumed it should work, without checking with anyone first. When I showed it, it wasn't quite what they needed, and I had to redo a good chunk of it. It wasn't a disaster, but it wasted time. What I learned is to always confirm my understanding before building anything, even when it feels obvious. Now I play the requirement back to the person in my own words, or show a quick sketch, before I start. That habit is a big part of why I'm drawn to BA work.

12. Tell me about a time you used data to make a recommendation.

At Motivolog, the team needed to decide on a pricing and licensing strategy for is.team. Rather than going on gut feel, I compared open-core licensing and pricing across 11 competing tools, covering what each one gives away for free, what's behind the paywall, the pricing tiers and the licence type. I put it all into one comparison table so the patterns were easy to see, like where most tools draw the line between free and paid. Based on that, I recommended a strategy that fit where is.team sits in the market. It made the conversation much easier, because we were discussing evidence instead of opinions.

13. How do you manage multiple priorities?

Right now I'm juggling my Master's, my internship at Motivolog, and two student roles, the Your Voice Student Network and the Better Together Committee, so I've had to get good at this. I keep everything in one place with deadlines, and each week I look at what's most urgent and what has the biggest impact. I block time in my calendar for focused work, and I try to be realistic about what I can take on. If

two things clash, I talk to the people involved early instead of letting something slip quietly. It's pretty much the same thinking as managing a backlog, just for my own week.

14. Tell me about a time you showed leadership.

As a student representative with the Your Voice Student Network at CDU, my role is to gather what students are experiencing, what's working and what needs to improve, and bring that back to the university. It's actually quite similar to BA work. You hear from lots of different people, a lot of the feedback overlaps or conflicts, and you have to pull out the common themes and present them clearly to the people who make decisions. I have also represented this network on our university orientation day, explaining new students how this network works and adding new members to the network.

15. Tell me about a time you had to learn something new quickly.

At Motivolog I had to take both of my apps through App Store and Google Play review, which I'd never done before. There's a lot involved, including privacy manifests and data-safety forms, and if something's wrong the app gets rejected. So I went through Apple's and Google's documentation carefully, looked at examples, and made a checklist of every requirement before submitting. Because we designed both apps to collect no user data, I had to make sure everything we declared matched how the apps actually behaved. Task Loop is now live on the App Store. I learn fastest by going to the official source first and then applying it straight away on something real.

16. How do you handle unclear or ambiguous requirements?

When requirements are unclear, I don't just guess and start building. I write down what I know, what I don't know and what I'm assuming, and then take that list back to the stakeholders to fill the gaps. A lot of the time people aren't sure what they want until they see something, so a quick sketch or prototype in Figma or Miro helps a lot. At Motivolog, the competitor analysis started out quite open-ended, so the first thing I did was agree on the specific question, which was pricing and licensing, before collecting any data. Narrowing it down early saved a lot of wasted effort.

17. What project are you most proud of?

I'd say Smart Learn. It's a gamified learning platform for students from grade 1 to 10, where you type in any topic and it turns it into a personalised course with lessons and six types of interactive quizzes, plus XP, streaks and a leaderboard to keep kids motivated. The part I'm proudest of is the AI feedback loop. It reviews each student's answers and then generates a revised course that targets their weak spots, so the learning adapts to each student. I also made sure sign-in was secure and student data stayed private, which really matters when you're dealing with kids. It taught me to always design around the real user and what they need.

18. How do you handle feedback or criticism?

I see feedback as a shortcut to getting better. At ViitorCloud, when I wrote my first technical documents, my senior told me they were too long and the key points were getting lost. I was a bit disappointed at first because I'd put a lot of work in, but I could see his point. So I asked him for a good example to follow, and started putting a short summary at the top with the detail underneath. The next reports

were much easier for the team to use. Now I ask for feedback early, because it's much easier to fix things at the start than at the end.

19. Where do you see yourself in five years?

In five years I'd like to be an experienced BA, leading requirements on bigger projects and helping newer BAs find their feet. I also want to get stronger on the data side, going deeper into SQL and Power BI, because I think BAs who can back up their recommendations with data are really valuable. Once I've got the experience, I'd like to work towards an IIBA certification like the CCBA or CBAP. And I'd like to be doing all of that here in the NT, where I can see the impact of the work on the community.

20. Why should we hire you?

I think I bring a mix that's really useful for a BA. I've got a software engineering background, so I understand how systems are built and I can talk to developers easily. I've also done real BA work, like gathering requirements through weekly client meetings, managing a backlog over six sprints, and comparing pricing across 11 competitor tools. I can work with data using SQL, Power BI and Excel, and I know Agile and Jira well, with the Atlassian certificate to back that up. On top of that, I'm a clear communicator, I learn quickly, and I'm committed to building my career here in Darwin. I'm ready to learn from your team and add value from day one.